

THE FAMILY MAN Kharge (left) with the late Indira Gandhi

Kharge is fluent in five—English, Hindi, Urdu, Kannada and Marathi. Party insiders expect his Dalit identity—he is the first Dalit president in five decades since Jagjivan Ram in 1970—to attract the Scheduled Caste vote. But the politics of symbolism doesn't always pay dividend like in Punjab where Dalit leader Charanjit Singh Channi replaced Amarinder as CM. Both leaders lost in their respective seats. "The party needs a relevant and appealing narrative in these states to counter the BJP's aggressive Hindutva nationalism, not rehashed symbolism," says the AICC in-charge of a north Indian state.

Even in the south, except in Kerala and Karnataka, the Congress is facing an existential crisis. After the bifurcation of Andhra Pradesh in 2014—seen as the Congress-led UPA government's gift to the newly carved Telangana—the party has been wiped out in both states. In fact, it has no representative, either in the assembly or the Lok Sabha, from the new Andhra Pradesh. Contrast this with 2009 when undivided Andhra sent 33 party MPs to the Lok Sabha, the most among all states.

The emergence of new forces such as the Aam Aadmi Party is making it difficult for the Congress to the hold on to even existing capital. If Delhi and Punjab have fallen to AAP, the Arvind Kejriwal-led party threatens to cause a further split in the Congress vote share in states such as Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh. In fact, these two poll-bound states will be Kharge's first litmus test.

Then there's the mega showdown—the 2024 general election—which is less than two years away. Most Congress leaders concur that the party, on its own, is in no position to take on the electoral might of the BJP. A practical strategy will be to develop working alliances based on smart pre-poll seat-sharing with other opposition parties to avoid a split in the non-BJP votes. "Kharge will need a hotline with the top leaders of parties such as the TMC, SP, RJD, which are strong in their respective states. Instead of playing big brother, he will have to be the mediator bringing all of them under one platform to revive the UPA," says a CWC member. While supporters say his affable demeanour and accessibility make him the right candidate for the job, critics believe he will remain a mere messenger of the family, creating another layer of bureaucracy within.

POLL-BOUND GUJARAT AND HIMACHAL WILL BE **KHARGE'S FIRST LITMUS TEST**, EVEN AS AAP LOOMS AS ANOTHER THREAT

Irrespective of the scepticism, Kharge has taken charge at a time when Rahul's Bharat Jodo Yatra has created a positive buzz around the party. The Congress has been at pains to dissociate the exercise from poll outcomes (it's not even going through Himachal and Gujarat), saying the goal is to prepare the ground for 2024. A 157-day jamboree covering 3,570 km across 12 states, wants to build a bipolar narrative—the BJP's divisive politics vs the Congress's inclusiveness.

Even if the mission succeeds, Kharge has his job cut out—translating the momentum into votes. In one sense, he could be the right person to do this. At the age of seven, Kharge lost his mother to communal violence, forcing the family to move from Warawatti, in the old Hyderabad-Karnataka region, to neighbouring Gulbarga (now Kalaburagi). That's why he has always been a strong opponent of communal politics.

But to take this inclusive narrative to voters, the dormant party organisation, which retains a pan-India presence, has to be resuscitated. At home, Kharge, ever a stickler for order, doesn't mind even polishing the shoes of his grandchildren if he sees they are dirty. He now needs to get his hands dirty cleaning up the Congress mess. The first step in that direction could be the implementation of the Udaipur resolution. To bring new blood to the party and present it in a new avatar to the voters, Kharge must fill up 50 per cent of the party positions with people younger than 50 years. He could begin with the formation of a new Congress Working Committee. ■